

► False advertising

Cornelius Bennett Harness made "electric" corsets (really magnetic) that he claimed were not only comfortable but would solve all manner of health problems. Many women asked for their money back after doctors proved him a fraud.

upon. Regency women had to tread a fine line between appearing superficial and sincere.

A conservative shift

When Queen Victoria came to the throne in 1837, the moral tone of society changed. This partly reflected the differing approaches of the two monarchs. The court of Victoria's predecessor George IV, the Prince Regent, was perceived as extravagant and morally fluid, whereas Victoria's reign was marked by strict morality and a greater focus on the private realm of the family. In the Victorian era, transgressions by women who broke sexual norms were taken particularly seriously. "Fallen women," who could be prostitutes or simply those caught having sex out of wedlock, were the



subject of pamphlets by social reformers who felt it their duty to rescue them. In high society, once a woman was deemed to be "ruined" by premarital sex, she had little hope of social acceptance or marriage.

The lower classes

In the 18th and 19th centuries, the majority of working class women were employed in domestic service (see pp. 192–193), which provided them with a steady income and a place to live. Female servants were cheaper than male servants, and by 1891, as many as one in three women between the ages of 15 and 20 worked in domestic service. They were often overworked and poorly treated, as well as subjected to sexual violence from men working in, living in, or visiting the house. While premarital sex was common for these women, both laws and social stigma punished those who bore illegitimate children.

▲ Caged in

A woman is helped into an oppressive crinoline cage, which was used to achieve the fashionable Victorian silhouette of the mid-19th century. They dramatically reshaped the female form, and were covered in heavy fabrics to fit the conservative mood.



"HAPPINESS IN MARRIAGE IS ENTIRELY A MATTER OF CHANCE."

JANE AUSTEN, *PRIDE AND PREJUDICE*, 1813